

Anthropology's Role in Development: A Sociological Perspective

Successive waves of theories have shaped sociological discourse on development projects. From the establishment of Global North and South categories to the latest World Inequality Report by Piquety in 2022, an undeniable evolution of frameworks has changed the very idea of development. In addition, shifts in the political and economic context resulted in various changes in the actors involved in development projects, the relations between them, how they studied and measured the field's impact. This has led to the rise and fall of widely different ways to view the role of development, paradigms such as modernization theory, dependency theory and post-development theory, which draw from previous examples to come to their own conclusions. One of the notable results of these processes is the gradual assimilation of anthropologists as developmental actors starting in the 1970's. In this paper, I aim at taking a sociological stance to explain the relationship between development and anthropology by looking at how anthropologists were integrated into development project, as well as the impact this encounter had on all three fields. I will explore the mutual influences of sociology, development, and anthropology, by drawing on how they conceptualize development and by mobilizing authors of all three fields. To do so, I will start by giving an account of how a sociological approach to development allowed for the incorporation of anthropology in its processes, then I will examine how the particular

circumstances leading to the creation of developmental anthropologists marked the field, and lastly I will go over the notable and lasting impacts of the framework developed by the intersection of developmental, sociological and anthropological components.

First of all, the conceptual divide between anthropology and development was bridged by sociological components. Development seems to be constructed around the concept of modernity and how to reach it: it attempts to regulate underdeveloped societies through external institutions that determine what changes are necessary to bring about better living conditions. On the other hand, anthropologists study the way people live, not how they ought to live, and condemned development because modernization risked the acculturation of societies as development induced western practices seen as having better living standards. Furthermore, as exposed in the *Anti-Politics Machine* (Ferguson 1954), World Bank investments to developmental projects only beneficiated states through governmental agencies, which furthered critics of specialist advocating for cultural preservation. Realizing the shortcomings of relying on economic studies to initiate aid, developmental agencies turned to other experts for guidance. Precisely by allowing a sociological approach that framed the values of development on ethical terms instead of on economic ones did this allow to bridge the gap with anthropology. Indeed, as explained in Ferguson's *Anthropology and it's Evil Twin* (1997), a new ontology for development shifted its goal to making people live good lives according to local values and principals by expanding their choices to help them enact a more informed and holistic form of freedom. Thus, as the new sociological framework dropped standardization and homogenization components from projects, anthropologists started considering the prospect of changing development from within. Additionally, the need for

professionals capable of deciphering local challenges and evaluating potential impacts of different aid approaches rose in developmental agencies since they now believed local arrangements were necessary in order to be successful. Ultimately, the integration of sociological components into development frameworks bridged the conceptual gap between anthropology and development, but we will now look into the remaining effective differences between these concepts and how they were overcome.

Secondly, despite the newfound common ground of sociocultural and developmental ideals, development anthropologists had to take a new approach in order to be fully incorporated in developmental projects. Many challenges remained after anthropologists came aboard as they now faced development experts, which Du Bois and Escobar both criticized for relying on competing institutions of knowledge that produced “poor results of technology and capital-intensive top- down interventions” (Escobar 1991). Still, as discussed above, they had just “developed a new sensitivity toward the social and cultural factors in their [development agencies] programs” (Escobar 1991), but the biggest problem now resided with the employers of anthropologists. The United-States aid program, United Nation technical agencies, and bilateral governmental development bodies now forced a bureaucracy on them which had multiple impacts. The first was to create a divide between those now called development anthropologists, who since operated within mainstream development institutions had to show success in order “to sell”, and the rest of the field which was skeptical of their peer’s findings since they only emphasized the positive aspects of their projects. If this divide condemned development anthropologists to be disregarded by the field they had just left, it also forced them to create a moral narrative based on ethical concerns to justify their work as actors of change and not merely as observers, as argued

by David Gow (2002). This narrative, with at its forefront the search for alternatives to development through a new approach to knowledge, cemented what is now known as post-developmentalism. It deconstructed pre-established norms such as “underdevelopment” and put an emphasis on the role of language in shaping our world, that in turn influenced development experts and sociologists in creating an appropriate vocabulary and literature. Essentially, the challenges faced by developmental anthropologists guided them to an ethical commitment to alternative paradigms such as post-developmentalism, of which we will now discuss the impact.

Thirdly, a heritage from post-developmental ideals has led to a surge in direct measurements as alternatives to economic growth. If post-developmental theory failed to provide a clear path forward as it unconditionally rejected modernity while overlooking the South’s ability to use development for its own good and its desire for increased consumerism, it nevertheless stuck in the field’s literature as a major questioner of the means and motivations of development and as the first to go beyond the economical aspect. Surpassing models based on economic growth is not a recent idea; according to Streeten (1981), the developmental economist Dudley Seers had even been advocating for a focus on direct measures of well being such as unemployment and inequality since the late 1960’s (Prasa & Zaloznaya, 2021). But only 20 years later with Amartya Sen and Mahbul ul Haq’s creation of the Human Development Index have United Nation Agencies started to consider direct measures, on which a majority of modern sociological findings rely. For example, the most recent world inequality report coordinated by Thomas Piketty in 2022, if primarily concentrated on wealth inequality, which is closely linked to economic growth, still offers extensive data on carbon emission, investment in education, and tax evasion; the intersectionality of the findings reflects that of the potential uses of such reports. Furthermore,

local arrangements in developmental projects are more alive than ever, with scholars pushing for new ways to associate foreign aid and civil society (Baqir 2009), or by fully incorporating aid beneficiaries in the development process (Easterly 2008). In summary, the legacy of post-developmentalism has made possible a shift towards direct measurement and reevaluation of development paradigms.

In conclusion, the evolution of sociological discourse on development projects has been marked by successive waves of theories and paradigms, each shaping and reshaping development. The assimilation of anthropologists as developmental actors starting in the 1970s reflects a significant shift in the approach to development. Initially bridged by sociological components, the conceptual divide between anthropology and development gave way to a more holistic understanding of development that takes into account social and cultural factors alongside economic ones. However, challenges persisted as anthropologists navigated competing institutional pressures and the need to justify their work within bureaucratic frameworks. The legacy of post-developmentalism continues to influence contemporary discourse on development, challenging traditional models based solely on economic growth and advocating for direct measures of well-being.

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